

Nigeria Security Incidents Analysis

Project Overview:

Nigeria has experienced fluctuating security challenges over the past decade, driven by insurgency, armed banditry, communal conflicts, and criminal activities. Understanding the patterns behind these incidents is critical for strategic intervention and resource allocation.

This project analyzes multi-year security incident data across Nigeria to uncover:

- National trends over time
- Geographic concentration of violence
- Dominant perpetrator groups
- Year-over-Year performance patterns
- Regional and state-level hotspots

Project Context & Objective:

This analysis examines **security incidents across Nigeria over multiple years**, with the goal of:

- Understanding **how security incidents are evolving over time**
- Identifying **geographic hotspots**
- Uncovering **key perpetrators driving insecurity**
- Understanding the hidden motive or agenda behind the insurgency
- Supporting **data-driven security planning and intervention**

The dashboard transforms raw incident records into **actionable national security insights**.

Methodology:

Data was gotten from a few security incidents reporting websites online. Incidents were grouped by recorded perpetrator category; using aggregation techniques, total incident counts were calculated per perpetrator and ranked in descending order to identify the dominant insurgent groups.

The analysis focused on the five most significant categories:

- **Boko Haram**
- **Armed Bandits**
- **Fulani Militants**
- **ISWAP (Islamic State West Africa Province)**
- **Unknown Gun Men**

Tools Used:

- ✓ SQL for data cleaning on the MySQL database, creating key insights, locking views, data aggregation and validation techniques
- ✓ DAX for KPI calculations and other important metrics
- ✓ SQL ODBC connector to connect live dataset to Power BI
- ✓ Power BI for Data modelling and visualization
- ✓ Microsoft Power Point for presentation

Key Findings:

- **Focused Responsibility**

A small number of recurring groups account for the majority of recorded incidents, showing that insecurity comes from known actors rather than random events.

- **Insurgency-Driven Activity**

Boko Haram and ISWAP remain central to insurgency-related incidents, with sustained operational presence across multiple years.

- **Localized Armed Violence**

Armed Bandits and Fulani Militants contribute significantly to regionally concentrated violence, particularly in recurring hotspot states.

- **Intelligence Gaps**

A notable proportion of incidents are attributed to “Unknown” perpetrators. This highlights limitations in attribution, reporting, or intelligence capabilities, which may affect policy precision.

Big Picture: National Incident Trend

➤ What is really happening in Nigeria?

- Total recorded incidents (900) show **clear year-to-year fluctuations**
- Some years, experience **sharp increase**  indicating periods of heightened Insecurity
- Other years show **temporary declines**, suggesting the impact of interventions or reporting changes.

Key Insight:

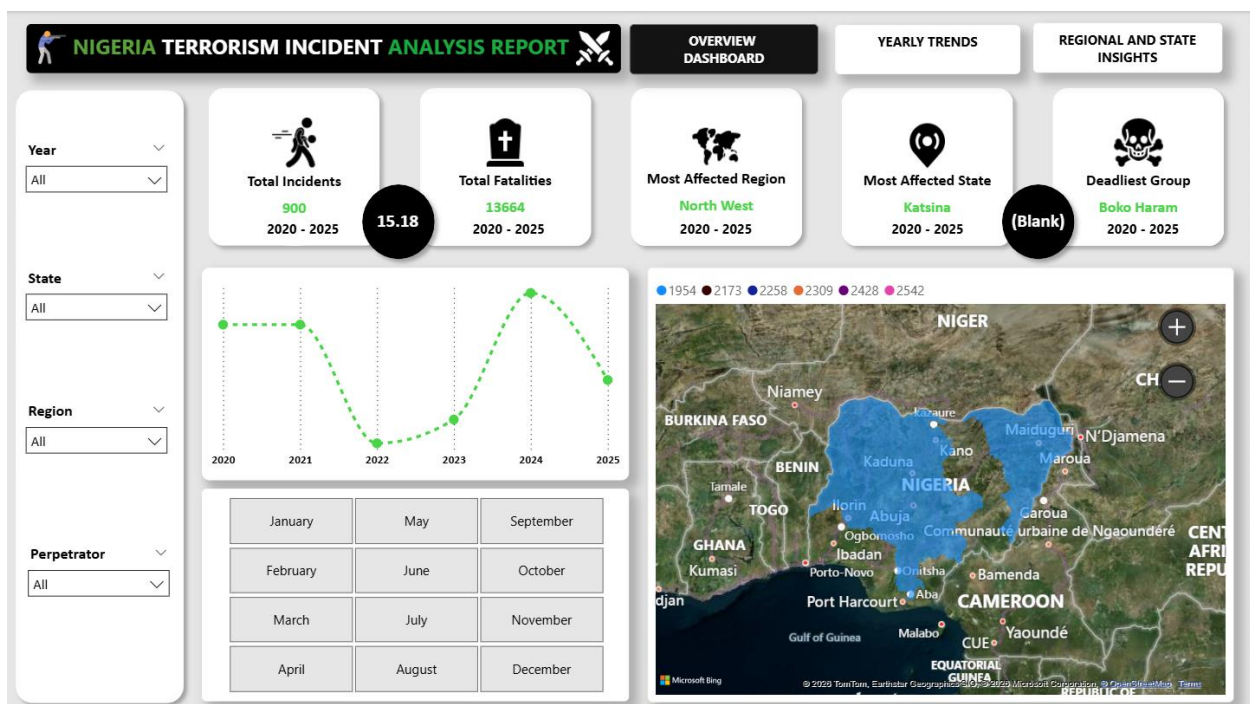
Security incidents in Nigeria are **not random**; they follow identifiable **temporal patterns**, making trend analysis critical for early warning and planning.

Key Performance Indicators:



- Total Incidents (900)
- Total Fatalities (13,664)
- Most Affected Region (North West)
- Most Affected State (Katsina)
- Deadliest Group (Boko Haram)

➤ Understanding the Motives Behind Terrorism Incidents & Killings



Data-Based Observations:

From the dashboard analysis:

Incidents are heavily concentrated in specific regions, with certain perpetrators dominating particular geographic zones. Some groups are characterized by a high frequency of attacks but

moderate fatalities, while others display lower frequency yet higher lethality. Additionally, kidnapping-related incidents tend to appear in identifiable clusters, highlighting distinct patterns in both occurrence and impact.

Interpreting Motives Through Data Patterns:

While the dataset does not directly record motive, patterns suggest several possible drivers:

1. Ideological / Insurgency Motives:

Perpetrators often operate consistently within specific regions mostly North-East and North-West demonstrating high attack repetition over multiple years. Their actions frequently involve targeted assaults on both civilian and state infrastructure, Christians and Muslims, reflecting deliberate strategic choices. This recurring pattern typically aligns with objectives rooted in territorial control or ideological insurgency (like the Islamic jihadists), underscoring the broader motivations driving such sustained campaigns.

2. Economic Motives:

Kidnapping incidents happen often. They usually don't kill many people but occur frequently because the goal might be financially driven, not mass harm. This shows that most of the attackers may be motivated by profit rather than politics or ideology.

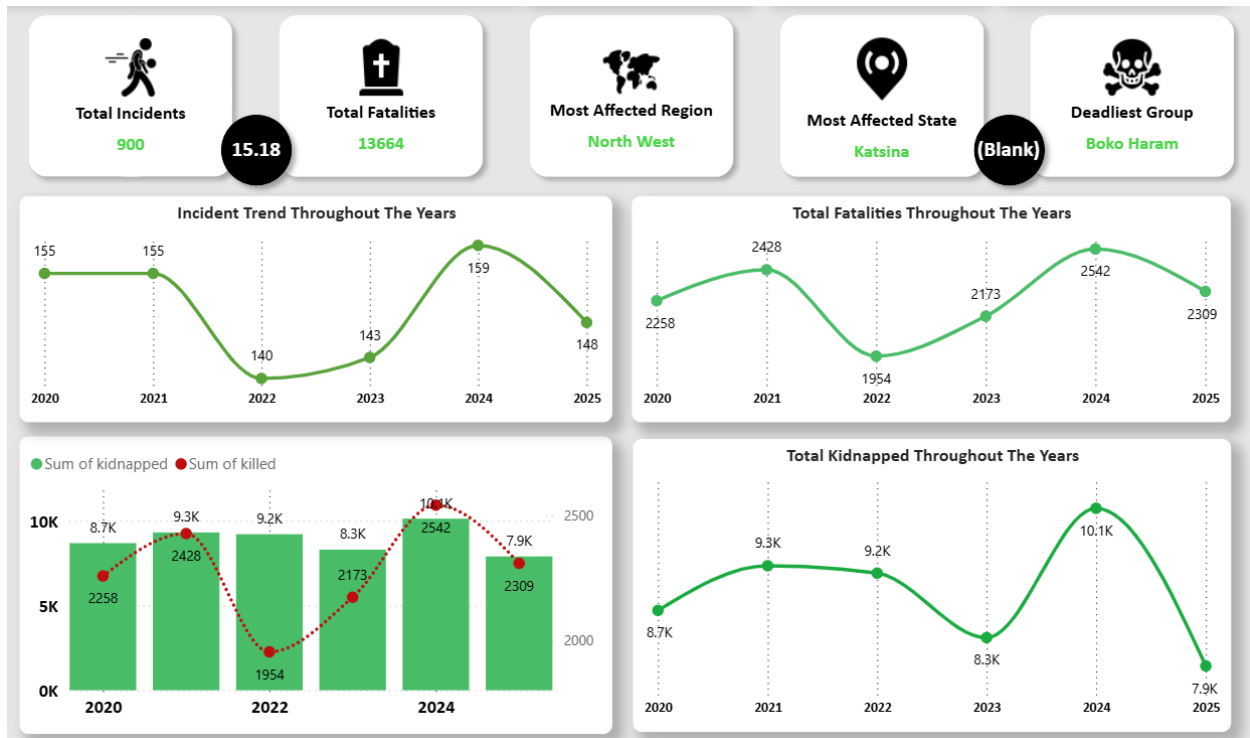
3. Communal / Resource Conflict Motives:

Incidents tend to be clustered in rural areas (above 800 of the recorded incidents), often recurring in the same conflict zones over time. This pattern may reflect underlying resource-based tensions or communal disputes, suggesting that local grievances and competition over land or resources play a significant role in driving these confrontations. There have been unconfirmed reports of illegal gold mining happening in some parts of the North-East, could this be a motivating factor too? Another reason could be the farmers-herders clash which has undoubtedly led to destruction of farmlands and deaths of so many farmers within these recorded regions.

Analytical Disclaimer:

While the dataset does not explicitly capture perpetrator motives, observed temporal and geographic patterns allow for reasonable analytical inference regarding ideological, economic, and resource-driven conflict dynamics.

➤ Year-on-Year (YoY) Performance (Yearly Trends)



Are things getting better or worse?

Year-on-year analysis reveals both positive and negative growth rates, reflecting fluctuations in incident trends over the 5-year period. Negative YoY values indicate years where incidents declined compared to the previous year, while positive YoY values highlight periods of escalation. Despite a brief improvement in 2022, insecurity escalated again and peaked in 2024. This dynamic pattern underscores the variability in incident occurrence across different years. A negative YoY percentage is **not an error** — it represents **improvement or reduced activity**, which is a critical insight for evaluating security efforts.

Yearly Trend Highlights

Incidents

- Incident counts are relatively stable with small fluctuations: **155 (2020), 155 (2021), 140 (2022), 143 (2023), 159 (2024), 148 (2025)**. This indicates **no single clear downward trend** in event frequency across the six years.
- Violence peaks during the rainy season and mid-year travel/farming period.

Fatalities (Deaths = 13,664)

- Fatalities show more variability and an upward pressure in some years: **2258 (2020), 2428 (2021), 1954 (2022), 2173 (2023), 2542 (2024), 2309 (2025)**. The **peak in 2024** and elevated counts in 2021 and 2025 point to episodic surges in lethality.

Kidnappings

- Kidnapping totals are large and volatile: **8.7K (2020), 9.3K (2021), 9.2K (2022), 8.3K (2023), 10.1K (2024), 7.9K (2025)**. The **2024 spike** to 10.1K is notable and aligns with the 2024 fatality peak. Sokoto, Zamfara, Katsina, Yobe, and Kebbi recorded the highest kidnapping figures during the study period, each exceeding 4,000 victims. The dominance of Northwestern states further confirms the region as Nigeria's core mass-abduction corridor, with kidnapping emerging as the most severe security threat.

Combined View

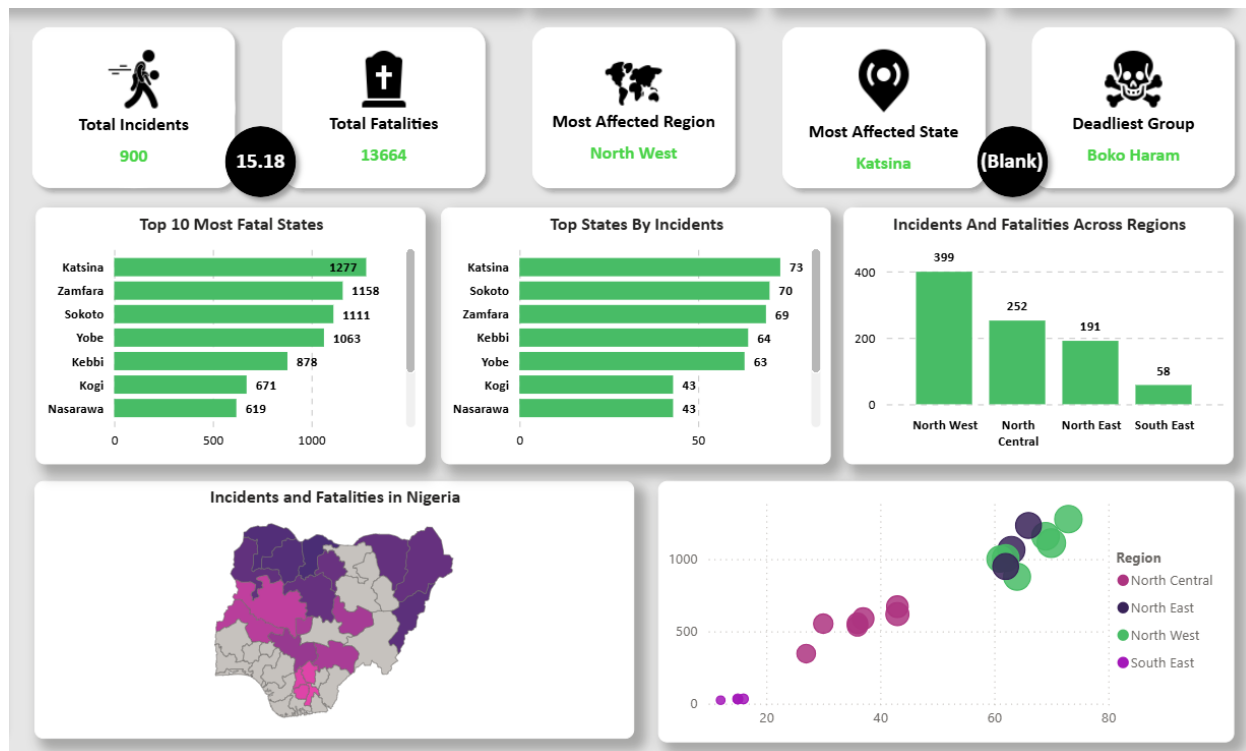
- Years with higher kidnappings (2021, 2022, 2024) tend to coincide with higher fatalities, with a combined **6,924** deaths recorded during that three-year period alone, suggesting **periods of intensified violence** rather than steady decline.

2022 showed a temporary improvement in both incidents (140) and fatalities (1954), while 2024 marked a major escalation with peaks across incidents, fatalities, and kidnappings; 2025 (incidents stood at **148** while fatalities were **2309**) indicates a retreat from that peak but remains above the 2022 low, pointing to a cycle of rising tensions instead of lasting peace. The years in which the insecurity took could suggest that efforts from the Nigerian military to push back these terrorists might have worked temporarily.

Recommendations

- Given Nigeria's economic constraints, security efforts should prioritize **targeted deployment in high-risk states** (Katsina, Kebbi, Zamfara, Yobe, Sokoto, Borno, Kogi etc.) rather than nationwide expansion. Strengthening **community policing** offers a low-cost but effective way to improve early warning and response.
- Efforts should also focus on **disrupting kidnapping financing systems**, by stopping ransom payments or settlements to these terrorists while improving **data reporting and inter-agency coordination** to reduce intelligence gaps.
- Long-term stability will depend on addressing **youth unemployment and economic hardship in hotspot regions**, as prevention is more sustainable and cost-effective than prolonged conflict response.

➤ Geographic Distribution of Incidents



📖 Where are incidents most concentrated?

Incidents are mostly found in just a few states and two sub-regions, instead of being spread evenly across the country. These few states make up a very large share of the total incidents, showing that the problem is not balanced everywhere. This clustering could point to diverse issues being the main drivers of insecurity in those areas.

Security threats in Nigeria are **highly regional**, meaning a one-size-fits-all security response is inefficient.

➤ Regional & State-Level Insights

📍 Which states are most affected?

- Top 10 states in Nigeria were identified based on incident volume;
- These states consistently appear across 2020-2025, signaling **persistent risk zones**.

Katsina State	Kogi State
Sokoto State	Nasarawa State
Zamfara State	Plateau State
Kebbi State	Kwara State
Yobe State	Niger State

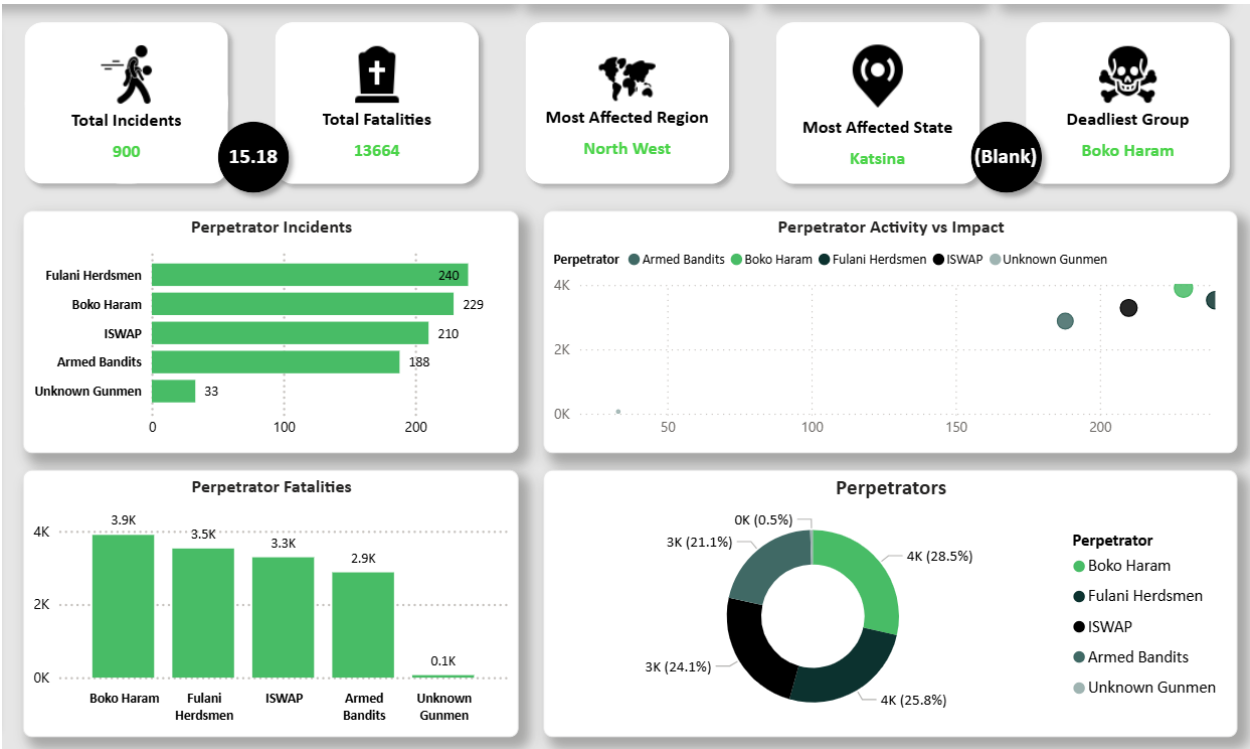
These states consistently appear across multiple years, signaling **persistent risk zones**.

The data show violence is concentrated in a small cluster of northern states, with the North West bearing the heaviest burden (399 incidents) and Katsina standing out as the worst-affected state—highest incident count (73) and fatalities (1,277)—closely followed by Zamfara and Sokoto; the South East records markedly lower incident volumes, and fatalities closely mirror incident patterns, underscoring high lethality in the identified hotspot states.

Recommendations:

- **Focus limited security resources on northern hotspot states** (especially North West) instead of spreading forces nationwide.
- **Strengthen collaboration** between federal forces, state governments, and regulated local vigilante groups to maximize impact without increasing costs.
- **Protect rural communities and key economic corridors** to reduce both violence and its impact on food prices and livelihoods.
- **Invest in youth employment and agricultural support** in high-burden states to address economic drivers of insecurity.

➤ **Perpetrator Analysis**



Who is driving the incidents?

Security incidents were categorized based on identified perpetrator groups. Analysis reveals that five key actors dominate the landscape of recorded violence:

- **Boko Haram** emerges as one of the most consistently active groups across multiple years contributing significantly to total incident volume.
- **Armed Bandits** show high frequency in specific regional clusters, often associated with kidnapping and localized attacks.
- **Fulani Militants** appear prominently in areas experiencing recurring communal and resource-related conflicts.
- **ISWAP**, while sometimes lower in total frequency compared to Boko Haram, demonstrates concentrated operational patterns.
- **Unknown / Unidentified perpetrators** represent a notable proportion of incidents, indicating gaps in attribution and intelligence reporting.

Key Insight

Nigeria's insecurity is mainly caused by a few repeat groups like Boko Haram, Armed Bandits, Fulani Militants, and ISWAP. At the same time, many incidents are blamed on unknown attackers, showing that intelligence and tracking remain difficult. Because the problem is concentrated among specific groups, focused intelligence-driven actions (like creating more military bases in the affected regions) would work better than broad, general security measures.

➤ Key Patterns Observed

Key Patterns Observed:

-  **Recurring hotspots** rather than new random locations
-  **Cycles of escalation and decline**, not linear improvement
-  **Regional concentration** of violence
-  **Repeat perpetrator dominance**

➤ Implications for Decision-Makers

Based on the analysis:

- Resources should be **prioritized toward high-impact states**
- Creating of more military bases in these affected regions to help combat the insurgents
- Improved perpetrator identification would significantly **enhance response strategies**
- Preventive action should focus on **trend acceleration periods**

Nigeria's security challenges are geographically concentrated, driven by repeat perpetrators, and exhibit clear year-to-year patterns, despite motive behind the incidents not categorically documented — data-driven, targeted interventions become even more essential.

Data Limitations and Assumptions

- Some incidents are categorized as “Unknown” perpetrator.
- Motives are inferred, not directly recorded.
- Year-to-Year calculations assume complete annual data.
- Reporting accuracy may vary across regions.

Executive Summary

This analysis examined terrorism and violent security incidents across Nigeria, identifying geographic concentration, perpetrator patterns, incident trends, and fatality distribution. The findings reveal a **highly concentrated security burden**, rather than a uniformly distributed national crisis.

The **North West emerges as the most affected region**, with states such as Katsina, Zamfara, and Sokoto consistently ranking highest in both incidents and fatalities. Fatality patterns closely mirror incident concentration, indicating not only frequent attacks but high lethality in key hotspot states.

Perpetrator analysis shows that a small number of identifiable armed groups (4) are responsible for the majority of recorded incidents. However, the continued presence of “unknown gunmen” or unattributed actors highlights intelligence and reporting gaps, limiting full accountability and strategic response precision.

A notable surge in kidnapping-related activities in recent years suggests an increasing **economic dimension to insecurity**, where criminal violence is driven not only by ideology but by financial incentives. This shift reflects deeper structural pressures within the Nigerian economy — including youth unemployment, inflation, rural poverty, and weakened local economic systems.

Importantly, the data suggests that insecurity in Nigeria is **geographically concentrated, economically influenced, and structurally reinforced**, rather than random or evenly spread.

Given Nigeria's fiscal constraints, rising cost of living, and limited security budgets, a nationwide force expansion is neither economically sustainable nor strategically optimal. Instead, the evidence supports:

- Targeted deployment in high-burden northern states
- Strengthened community policing and intelligence systems
- Disruption of kidnapping and criminal financing networks
- Improved data attribution and inter-agency coordination

- Long-term socioeconomic stabilization in hotspot regions

Security interventions must therefore balance immediate operational response with economically realistic prevention strategies.

Closing Insight

The data makes one conclusion clear:

Nigeria's security crisis is not merely a military challenge -- it is a **data, ideologic, economic, and governance challenge**. Sustainable improvement will require smarter allocation of limited resources, deeper community engagement and policing, improved intelligence systems, expansion or creating more military bases and targeted socioeconomic intervention in the most affected regions.

A focused, intentional and evidence-driven approach by the security agents including the whole country's security architecture — rather than broad reactive deployment — offers the strongest path toward measurable and sustainable national stability.